
DIPLOMATIC EMERGENCY INSTRUMENT

The Strait Freeze Protocol

*A Minimum Viable Ceasefire Consolidation Framework
with Northern Front Extension (Israel – Lebanon)*

Track A: The United States of America & the Islamic Republic of Iran

Track B: The State of Israel & the Lebanese Republic

(with linkage provisions, technical appendix, and classified annex)

Reference: SFP-2026-v1.4

Date of Issue: 26 May 2026

Status: For Immediate Consideration

Facilitators: Sultanate of Oman, State of Qatar, United States (Track B)

This instrument is deliberately short. It resolves only one thing: whether all four parties will stop shooting long enough to talk. It does not resolve the nuclear file, the sanctions architecture, the future of the Strait, the disarmament of Hezbollah, or Israeli troop positions in southern Lebanon. Those questions are explicitly deferred.

Preamble: Recital and Purpose

Recital – The Triggering Crisis

Whereas, on or about 26 May 2026, United States Central Command conducted self-described 'self-defence strikes' against missile launch sites and mine-laying vessels near Bandar Abbas, southern Iran — some 70 kilometres from the Strait of Hormuz — resulting in IRGC personnel casualties and explosions confirmed by Iranian media; and

Whereas, on or about the same date, Israeli forces and Hezbollah clashed along a strategic river in southern Lebanon as Israeli troops attempted to push farther north, with one Israeli strike on the village of Mashghara killing twelve people including members of one family, and with Prime Minister Netanyahu having instructed the IDF to 'press the pedal even harder'; and

Whereas, an Iranian delegation led by parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf was concurrently travelling to Doha for negotiations, and Israeli and Lebanese delegations were scheduled to convene in Washington on 29 May 2026, with the Pakistan-mediated U.S.-Iran ceasefire of 8 April 2026 and the U.S.-mediated Israel-Lebanon ceasefire of 16 April 2026 both in formal force but operationally deteriorating; and

Whereas, the Parties recognise that no comprehensive treaty can be negotiated while active kinetic operations are occurring, and that a minimum-viable, time-bounded operational pause is therefore a prerequisite to any substantive talks;

Now therefore, the Parties have agreed the following Protocol, which operates as a re-usable framework for any analogous 72-hour de-escalation requirement and is not bound to the specific dates of its initial activation except where expressly stated.

PURPOSE OF THIS INSTRUMENT: This protocol does not attempt to resolve any permanent status issue. It is a single-purpose emergency instrument designed to stop the operational bleeding on two fronts simultaneously — the Strait of Hormuz (Track A) and the Israel-Lebanon border (Track B) — and to create 72 hours of genuine silence in which broader negotiations can advance. Nothing in this document prejudices any party's position on the nuclear file, sanctions, the PGSA, Hezbollah's disarmament, Israeli withdrawal, or war reparations.

NO PRECEDENT CLAUSE. This Protocol establishes no legal or political precedent for any future negotiation, instrument, or proceeding. Each provision is tailored to the emergency circumstances of its activation. Nothing herein shall be cited, invoked, or relied upon by any Party, third state, international organisation, or tribunal as evidence of customary international law, opinio juris, or binding interpretation of any other treaty, agreement, or understanding. Signature, implementation, or invocation of any provision shall not prejudice the legal position of any Party in any other forum.

Architecture: Two Tracks, One Floor

This Protocol operates on two parallel tracks, linked at five carefully chosen points. Each track has its own parties, its own facilitator, and its own obligations. Neither track requires the other to function. But because both fronts are now feeding each other's escalation, this Protocol allows them to de-escalate in synchrony.

	Track A – Southern Front	Track B – Northern Front
Parties	United States & Iran	Israel & Lebanese Republic
Theatre	Strait of Hormuz, Persian Gulf, Iranian territorial waters	Israel-Lebanon border, southern Lebanon, northern Israel
Facilitator	Oman (lead), Qatar (host of current delegation)	United States (existing mediator since April 16 truce)
Spoiler	IRGC hardliners, U.S. hawks pushing maximalist demands	Hezbollah (rejects state-to-state talks), Israeli ultra-right cabinet members
What success looks like	72 hours of no strikes; Hormuz open to commercial traffic; blockade suspended	72 hours of no IDF strikes in Lebanon; no Hezbollah fire into Israel; delegation talks proceed

Part I: Track A – The Southern Front (U.S. – Iran)

Article 1: Immediate Cessation of Offensive Action

Upon entry into force of this Protocol, both Parties to Track A commit to an immediate, unconditional pause on all offensive military operations directed at the other Party's forces, vessels, aircraft, and fixed infrastructure. This pause takes effect at the moment of joint notification to the Omani and Qatari facilitators and requires no further documentation, ratification, or counter-signature to be binding.

The pause covers:

- All CENTCOM strikes on Iranian soil, territorial waters, and Iranian-flagged vessels.
- All IRGC naval operations involving interdiction, harassment, or mine-laying in or near the Strait of Hormuz.
- All drone and missile deployments by either Party directed at the other's forces.
- All cyber operations targeting the other Party's military command infrastructure.

The pause does not cover legitimate self-defence responses to incoming kinetic attack (defined as actual weapons fire or imminent physical threat to personnel as specified in Appendix I §1 — not surveillance, signalling, or posturing). Any self-defence action must be immediately reported to both facilitators within two hours of occurrence, through the secure reporting channel specified in Appendix I §2.

Article 2: The 72-Hour Window

The initial freeze period is 72 hours, automatically renewable. At Hour 70, both facilitators (Oman and Qatar) confirm to each Party whether the other has maintained compliance. If both confirm compliance, the freeze auto-renews for a further 72 hours without any additional action required. Renewal continues indefinitely until either Party delivers a written non-renewal notice to both facilitators with six hours advance notice — sufficient time to allow negotiators to reach safety.

This auto-renewal mechanism is the central structural feature of this Protocol. It removes the need for either side to make an active political decision to continue the freeze. Silence equals continuation. Only a deliberate, written act ends it.

Article 3: The Hormuz Minimum

Within 48 hours of this Protocol entering into force, Iran commits to permitting unrestricted passage of all commercial vessels through the Strait of Hormuz, subject only to standard UNCLOS navigation rules. No PGSA transit permits, tolls, or inspection requirements apply during the freeze period. The legal and sovereign status of PGSA authority is explicitly deferred — this is a temporary operational suspension, not a legal concession by Iran on its regulatory rights. For purposes of this Article, 'commercial vessel' means any ship engaged in lawful trade, including oil tankers, container ships, bulk carriers, LNG and LPG carriers, general cargo vessels, and roll-on/roll-off ships. Military auxiliary vessels, naval logistics ships, replenishment oilers, and ships providing operational support to armed forces are **excluded** from this definition regardless of nominal flag or ownership.

Simultaneously, the United States commits to suspending enforcement of its naval blockade on Iranian commercial ports for the duration of the freeze. U.S. Navy vessels will not board, inspect, or interdict Iranian-flagged commercial vessels.

3.1 – Naval Stand-Off Distance. U.S. Navy vessels shall maintain a minimum five (5) nautical mile distance from the Iranian territorial waters baseline in the Strait transit corridor. Iranian naval vessels (regular Navy and IRGC Navy) shall maintain an equivalent five (5) nautical mile distance from the internationally marked shipping lanes in the Strait. Both distances are verifiable by satellite telemetry, AIS data, and Omani naval observers. Carrier strike groups shall remain at their positions at the moment of entry into force or further from Iranian territorial waters, never closer.

3.2 – PGSA Operational Recognition. The Persian Gulf Strait Authority is recognised as the designated Iranian operational coordination body for transit during the freeze period. **This recognition is operational, not legal.** It does not confer or withhold international legal status upon the PGSA, does not bind any Party to accept PGSA jurisdiction in any future negotiation, and is automatically extinguished upon the termination

of this Protocol.

3.3 – No Provocative Manoeuvres. Neither Party shall conduct: simulated attacks; close-range intercepts within three (3) nautical miles of the other Party's naval assets; laser illumination of vessels, aircraft, or personnel; deployment of uncrewed surface or undersea vessels within three (3) nautical miles of the other Party's naval assets; or 'unmasking' radar lock-on tactics. These activities, although non-kinetic, constitute Tier 1 incidents under Article 12 upon JFMC verification.

3.4 – Iranian Maritime Restraint. In addition to the cessation of offensive operations under Article 1, Iran specifically commits, for the duration of the freeze period, to: (a) no new mine-laying operations of any kind, anywhere in the Persian Gulf or Gulf of Oman; (b) no deployment of anti-ship cruise missiles or coastal defence missiles into launch-ready position along the Strait; and (c) no small-boat or fast-attack-craft swarm formations of three or more vessels within ten (10) nautical miles of the international transit corridor. Existing legacy mines in the water at the time of entry into force shall be disclosed to the JFMC within 24 hours and a joint clearance schedule established with Omani naval support.

3.5 – Joint Transit Coordination Cell (JTCC). A provisional Joint Transit Coordination Cell shall be established at Muscat, staffed by Iranian, U.S., and Omani officers at the rank of captain or commander, with a designated rotating chair. The JTCC's function is purely operational: it monitors AIS data, coordinates patrol schedules to prevent inadvertent close approach, responds to distress calls, and deconflicts air-sea operations in the transit corridor. **The JTCC has no boarding, interdiction, inspection, or enforcement authority.** The JTCC operates 24/7 for the duration of the freeze and reports to the JFMC on any incident that crosses the Article 12 reporting threshold.

Article 4: Humanitarian Corridor – Non-Negotiable

Regardless of any other provision, and regardless of any breach, dispute, or suspension, a zero-cost, zero-delay humanitarian corridor through the Strait of Hormuz is established effective immediately upon entry into force. This corridor applies to all vessels carrying verified humanitarian cargo as enumerated in Appendix I §4 (food, medicine, civilian fuel, and humanitarian relief supplies, with specific Harmonized System tariff codes listed) certified by WHO, ICRC, or an equivalent designated authority. Oman's Royal Navy serves as the sole verification and escort authority. The corridor is legally non-divertible.

Article 5: Protection of Negotiating Delegations

Both Track A Parties affirm that the delegations currently present in Doha, Qatar — including the Iranian delegation led by parliament speaker Qalibaf and any U.S. counterparts — are protected persons under this Protocol. Qatar is designated as a protected neutral venue for the duration of negotiations.

Part II: Track B – The Northern Front (Israel – Lebanon)

Track B addresses the Israel-Hezbollah conflict through the Lebanese state as formal counterparty. This design is deliberate. Hezbollah is not a signatory and will not be. The Lebanese government, which has publicly committed to disarming Hezbollah, is the only Lebanese authority with legal capacity to enter international agreements. Iran's leverage over Hezbollah is treated as Iran's contribution to Track B — delivered through Track A, not through any direct Iranian signature here.

DESIGN NOTE – WHY THIS CAN WORK: The Lebanese government supports state monopoly on arms. Israel and Lebanon already have a direct talks track scheduled in Washington (29 May). The U.S. has been the mediator since April 16. The missing piece is not diplomatic willingness — it is a 72-hour silence in which the Washington talks can actually happen. That is the only thing Track B asks of either party.

Article 6: Israeli Operational Pause

Upon entry into force of this Protocol, the State of Israel commits to an immediate pause on all offensive ground operations, air strikes, and artillery shelling inside Lebanese territory. The pause covers Tyre, Nabatieh, the Beqaa Valley, Beirut and its southern suburbs, Mashghara, and all other locations within Lebanon. Israeli forces currently inside Lebanese territory hold their positions and do not advance northward.

6.1 – Definition of 'Advancement'. Advancement includes any movement of armoured vehicles, infantry units, drones in attack profile, or engineering equipment beyond five hundred (500) metres from the positions held at the moment of entry into force. Movements *within* the 500-metre envelope, and movements *rearward* from current positions, are not advancement. Resupply convoys, casualty evacuation, and rotation of personnel may exit the envelope only with prior notification to the JFMC through the Portal, with departure point, destination, route, vehicle count, and return time. Surveillance overflights within established patrol patterns are not advancement.

The pause does not cover legitimate defensive responses to direct kinetic attack on Israeli territory or forces. As in Track A, this exception is narrow and is governed by the technical definition in Appendix I §1: actual incoming fire or imminent physical threat to personnel — not surveillance, posture, or rhetoric.

Article 7: Lebanese State Commitments

The Lebanese Republic commits to two obligations during the freeze period:

- **Active suppression of cross-border fire.** The Lebanese Armed Forces will deploy to known Hezbollah launch points in southern Lebanon — defined in Appendix I §5 by reference to UNIFIL's pre-existing geographic registry of launch sites observed between 8 April 2026 and the entry-into-force date, supplemented by any further sites identified by UNIFIL during the freeze period — in coordination with UNIFIL, and physically interpose between launch teams and the border. The LAF is not required to disarm Hezbollah units during the 72-hour period — only to physically prevent firing.

- **Confirmation of the 29 May Washington talks.** The Lebanese delegation will travel as scheduled. Any postponement requires 48 hours written notice to the U.S. facilitator and to Israel.
- **Non-crossing of the Blue Line.** Lebanon commits that no armed personnel under its command, control, or operational direction — whether LAF, General Security Directorate, State Security, Internal Security Forces, customs authorities, or any other state agency — shall cross the Blue Line into Israeli territory or into the area of Israeli operational deployment. The cross-border fire suppression obligation extends to direct orders binding on all Lebanese security services, not only the LAF.

7.1 – UNIFIL Concurrence. The Lebanese Republic shall seek and obtain UNIFIL's operational concurrence for joint deployment under this Article within six (6) hours of entry into force, through the standing UNIFIL liaison at the LAF General Command. If UNIFIL is unable or unwilling to provide concurrence within that window — whether for mandate reasons, operational capacity reasons, or otherwise — the LAF shall deploy independently with formal written notification to UNIFIL, the JFMC, and the Secretary-General of the United Nations. UNIFIL's non-participation shall not be treated as a Lebanese failure to perform under Article 9(b).

Article 8: The Hezbollah Question

Hezbollah is not a party to this Protocol and is not asked to sign anything. The Protocol does not, and cannot, require Hezbollah's consent. It does require the Lebanese state to use the means at its disposal — LAF deployment, coordination with UNIFIL, and political pressure — to physically prevent further cross-border fire during the 72-hour window.

Iran's contribution to Track B is delivered through Track A. As a confidence-building measure linked to the U.S. pause on strikes against Iran, Iran will privately convey to Hezbollah that an attack during the Track B freeze period will not be supported, supplied, or politically defended by Tehran. This commitment is formalised in **Annex C (Classified)** — a binding, sealed annex of equal legal force to the public articles of this Protocol, deposited with the Omani facilitator and shared with the U.S. facilitator under seal. The existence of Annex C is acknowledged publicly; its content is not. Breach of Annex C constitutes a Track A compliance issue actionable under Article 12.

8.1 – Six-Hour Side-Letter Delivery Deadline. Iran shall deliver the executed text of Annex C to the Omani facilitator through the JFMC Portal or sealed diplomatic pouch within six (6) hours of entry into force. The Omani facilitator shall confirm receipt to the U.S. facilitator within one (1) hour of delivery, without disclosing the content of the Annex. Failure to deliver within the six-hour window is a Track A Tier 2 compliance issue under Article 12 and may be raised by the United States without prejudice to the continuation of the Track A freeze itself.

8.2 – Hezbollah Voluntary Restraint Acknowledgment. If Hezbollah voluntarily issues a public or semi-public statement of restraint, ceasefire compliance, or non-engagement during the freeze period, the Lebanese government may note this as non-binding political cover and may communicate the fact of the statement to the JFMC. Neither Israel nor the United States is required to acknowledge, validate, or treat as binding any such Hezbollah statement. The statement does not transform Hezbollah into a Party to this

Protocol, does not bind Hezbollah legally, and does not relieve the Lebanese government of its Article 7 obligations. This provision exists solely to give Hezbollah a face-saving off-ramp through which it may, if it chooses, decline to fire without appearing to capitulate.

Article 9: If Hezbollah Fires Anyway

A Hezbollah strike during the freeze does not automatically collapse Track B. Israel may respond defensively to incoming fire at the source of fire, calibrated to neutralise the immediate threat, without invalidating the broader pause. The Lebanese government is not held responsible for Hezbollah's actions, provided it has demonstrably attempted the LAF deployment required under Article 7. Track B collapses only if (a) a confirmed Hezbollah strike causes significant Israeli casualties as defined in Appendix I §6 (ten or more deaths, or twenty or more serious injuries requiring hospitalisation, within a single 24-hour period, attributable to a single attributable Hezbollah action or coordinated series of actions), or (b) the Lebanese government refuses or fails to deploy LAF under Article 7 within 12 hours of entry into force.

9.1 – Lebanese Civilian Casualty Review. The casualty thresholds above are asymmetric on their face. To prevent that asymmetry from becoming politically unsustainable for the Lebanese Republic, a separate review trigger applies: if Israeli defensive action under this Article results in thirty (30) or more confirmed Lebanese civilian deaths within any single 24-hour period, or in sixty (60) or more confirmed Lebanese civilian serious injuries within the same window, the JFMC shall conduct an **emergency proportionality review** within 12 hours. The review is conducted by the U.S. Track B Compliance Monitor in consultation with the IAEA technical advisor (Article 11.6 below), the ICRC, and UNIFIL. The review does not automatically collapse Track B. Track B collapses under this paragraph only upon a JFMC finding of disproportionate or indiscriminate response in violation of Article 6 or applicable international humanitarian law. The threshold of disproportionality is assessed against the scale and nature of the Hezbollah action that triggered the Israeli response.

This asymmetric design reflects a structural reality: Hezbollah operates from within civilian areas, and any defensive Israeli response carries elevated civilian risk. The review mechanism allows Lebanon to invoke proportionality without granting Hezbollah a veto by hostage-taking through proximity.

Part III: Linkage Between the Tracks

The two tracks are deliberately separable but linked at five carefully chosen points. Anything outside these five linkages is independent.

Article 10: Hard Linkages Between the Tracks

- **Linkage 1 – Iran's leverage over Hezbollah.** Iran's commitment to withhold support from Hezbollah operations during the freeze (Article 8) is a Track A obligation as well as a Track B input. Documented failure of Iran to convey this message, if directly traceable, may be raised as a Track A compliance issue. Delivery of Annex C within the six-hour deadline (Article 8.1) is the operational test of this Linkage at entry into force.
- **Linkage 2 – Synchronised entry into force.** Both tracks enter into force subject to the six-hour synchronised confirmation window of Article 16.1. If at the close of that window confirmation has been received from fewer than all four Parties, the confirming Parties may proceed on a single-track basis at their discretion.
- **Linkage 3 – Independent collapse.** Collapse of one track does NOT collapse the other. If Track B fails — for example, by way of a confirmed large-scale Hezbollah strike causing significant Israeli casualties — the U.S.-Iran freeze in Track A continues uninterrupted. If Track A fails, the Israel-Lebanon freeze in Track B continues, with the United States as sole facilitator.
- **Linkage 4 – No Contradictory Back-Channel Messaging.** Neither Iran nor the United States shall communicate guidance through channels outside this Protocol that contradicts its public obligations under this Protocol — whether to Hezbollah, the IRGC's external operations apparatus, the Israeli government, U.S. force commanders in the theatre, or any other actor. The prohibition extends to public statements, private diplomatic communications, social media messaging, intelligence channel communications, and military-to-military communications. Any such contradictory message, if verified by the JFMC under Article 14 fact-finding procedures, constitutes a Tier 2 incident under Article 12 by the Party that issued it.
- **Linkage 5 – The 48-Hour Attribution Firewall.** If a proxy strike or incident attributable to a non-signatory actor occurs during the freeze, neither Party may unilaterally declare a material breach of this Protocol. The JFMC has forty-eight (48) hours to conduct forensic attribution, supported as needed by a Facilitator Fact-Finding Mission under Article 14 and by the IAEA technical advisor (Article 11.6) where nuclear material is alleged to be involved. **During the 48-hour attribution window, the freeze continues across both tracks.** Only the JFMC's attribution finding can trigger Tier 2 or higher escalation. This Linkage exists because hair-trigger attribution by the affected Party would, in every prior Middle East de-escalation, have terminated the framework before any verification could occur.

THE FIREWALL PRINCIPLE: Each track is firewalled from the other's failure. This is the most important structural feature of the dual-track design. A Hezbollah rocket, an IRGC mine, or an Israeli cabinet vote does not bring down the entire architecture. Each front fails or survives on its own. The 48-hour attribution window (Linkage 5) ensures that even confirmed incidents do not become protocol-killers before forensic review. The Protocol is engineered for partial success even when partial failure is occurring elsewhere.

Part IV: What This Protocol Deliberately Excludes

To be agreed quickly, this Protocol must be narrow. The following issues are explicitly deferred to subsequent negotiation phases that this Protocol is designed to protect and enable:

Issue	Deferred To
Iran's HEU stockpile — custody, location, quantity	Track A MOU Phase 2
Enrichment moratorium — duration and scope	Track A MOU Phase 2
Sanctions relief — timing, tranches, reversibility	Track A MOU Phase 2
Frozen Iranian assets — release schedule	Track A MOU Phase 2
PGSA legal status and Hormuz governance	Track A MOU Phase 2
Hezbollah disarmament timeline and scope	29 May Washington talks & beyond
Israeli withdrawal from Lebanese territory	29 May Washington talks & beyond
Lebanese state monopoly on arms — enforcement	Internal Lebanese process
War reparations / reconstruction credits	Successor framework
Regional proxy activity in Yemen, Iraq, Syria	Separate regional track
Long-term nuclear enrichment rights	Successor framework

The exclusion of these issues is not weakness — it is architecture. Every prior negotiation collapsed because all sides attempted to resolve everything simultaneously. This Protocol resolves only the immediate operational question on each front: will the shooting stop long enough for the delegations now in motion to finish their work?

Part V: Verification – Minimal and Practical

Article 11: Joint Freeze Monitoring Cell (JFMC)

Oman, Qatar, and the United States each designate a single senior diplomatic officer as Compliance Monitor for the duration of the Protocol. These three officers form the Joint Freeze Monitoring Cell (JFMC). Oman holds Track A primacy; the United States holds Track B primacy; Qatar holds delegation-protection primacy. The JFMC has one function: to receive reports of alleged violations, assess them against the definitions in this Protocol, and communicate findings to all relevant parties within four hours.

11.1 – Standardised Reporting Channel. All notifications to the JFMC — incident reports, self-defence reports, non-renewal notices, requests for fact-finding missions — must be submitted through the dedicated end-to-end encrypted secure web portal hosted on Omani sovereign infrastructure (the 'JFMC Portal'). The Portal provides redundant backup via encrypted satellite phone link and a third-fallback diplomatic courier channel through the Sultanate of Oman's diplomatic pouch system. Time-stamping is server-side and immutable. Notifications submitted by any other method — informal email, social media statement, press conference — do not trigger JFMC obligations and do not start any clock.

11.2 – Required Evidence for Reports. A Tier 1 incident report must include, at minimum: (a) time-stamped imagery, sensor logs, or AIS data; (b) GPS coordinates of the alleged incident; (c) the reporting party's good-faith attribution and basis; and (d) the article of this Protocol the report alleges to have been breached. Reports failing to include all four elements are returned to the reporting party as non-conforming and do not start the 4-hour consultation clock until cured. This prevents frivolous or speculative reporting from consuming the JFMC's narrow capacity.

11.3 – Data Mirroring. Every conforming report received by the JFMC is transmitted in full to all four signatory parties simultaneously, via the JFMC Portal, within fifteen minutes of receipt. No party receives any incident report before any other party. This rule applies regardless of which track the incident concerns. Transparency among all four parties is structural, not discretionary.

11.4 – Default Inference Rule. If the party against whom an allegation is made fails to respond to the JFMC's request for explanation within the 4-hour Tier 1 consultation window, the JFMC may, solely for its own internal monitoring assessment, treat the allegation as provisionally substantiated. This inference does not constitute a binding legal finding, does not by itself escalate to Tier 2, and may be rebutted at any time by subsequent evidence. Its sole effect is to permit the JFMC to inform the other three parties accordingly and to weight subsequent pattern analysis.

11.5 – Good Faith Clause. Each Party undertakes not to spoof, jam, suppress, intercept, manipulate, or interfere with the JFMC Portal, its supporting infrastructure, the redundant backup channels, the AIS feeds and sensor inputs relied upon by the JFMC, or the communications of any Compliance Monitor in the performance of his or her duties. Documented breach of this clause is automatically classified as a Tier 2 incident under Article 12, regardless of any direct kinetic effect.

11.6 – IAEA Technical Advisor. The International Atomic Energy Agency shall designate a single senior technical officer as Technical Advisor to the JFMC for the duration of the Protocol. The IAEA Technical Advisor is **not** a Compliance Monitor and has no voting role in JFMC determinations. The Advisor's function is strictly consultative: to provide independent technical assessment on any alleged incident involving nuclear material, fissile or radiological substances, vessels carrying nuclear-relevant cargo, or potential damage to nuclear facilities. IAEA findings are advisory only, but are deposited with the JFMC under Article 11.3 (Data Mirroring) and distributed to all four Parties. The Advisor is bound by IAEA confidentiality protocols and may not disclose information obtained in this role outside the JFMC structure without the consent of the affected Parties.

The JFMC does not have authority to suspend the freeze, declare a breach, or impose consequences. Its role is purely informational. Consequences are governed by Article 12.

Article 12: Tiered Incident Response – No Hair Triggers

A single alleged violation does not suspend this Protocol. Both fronts are congested, high-tension operational environments. Accidents, miscommunications, and deliberate provocations by spoilers will occur. The Protocol survives them through a tiered response architecture applied identically to both tracks:

Tier	Trigger	Response	Timeline
1 — Incident	Single alleged violation reported to JFMC	JFMC notifies relevant parties; 4-hour consultation window opens; freeze continues	0–4 hours
2 — Pattern	Three Tier 1 incidents within 24 hours, or one confirmed lethal strike	JFMC convenes emergency session; foreign ministers contacted; 12-hour resolution window	4–16 hours
3 — Crisis	Large-scale offensive operation (10+ casualties or major infrastructure strike)	Facilitators convene in-person reconstitution within 6 hours; UN notified; freeze enters 'amber' status	6–24 hours
4 — Collapse	Mandatory cooling-off consultation under Article 12.2, followed by written non-renewal notice if unresolved	6-hour cooling-off + 6-hour buffer; the other track continues; humanitarian corridor survives	12 hours total

The humanitarian corridor established in Article 4 survives all four tiers, including full Protocol collapse on either or both tracks. It is not subject to suspension, modification, or revocation by any Party under any circumstances during any active negotiation process.

12.1 – Tier 2 Conflict Resolution Timeline. Upon Tier 2 classification, the following sequence is mandatory and time-bound:

- **Hour 0–2:** JFMC issues simultaneous Tier 2 notification to all four parties via the JFMC Portal, with a complete evidence packet and the JFMC's preliminary assessment.
- **Hour 2–4:** The foreign ministers (or designated representatives at the same rank) of all directly affected parties enter a single secure conference call hosted by the JFMC. Lower-rank substitution requires written agreement of the other parties.
- **Hour 4–8:** The affected parties propose, in writing through the Portal, remedial steps and any positional clarifications. The JFMC consolidates these into a single resolution memorandum.
- **Hour 8–12:** Foreign ministers reconvene to accept, reject, or modify the resolution memorandum. Acceptance by all directly affected parties returns the matter to Tier 1 status. Failure to reach acceptance auto-escalates to Tier 3.

12.2 – Mandatory Cooling-Off Before Non-Renewal. Before a Party may file a written non-renewal notice under Article 15, that Party shall first request a cooling-off consultation through the JFMC Portal. Upon receipt of the request, the JFMC shall convene a six (6)-hour secure consultation session, attended by the intending Party, the other Party to the affected track, and the relevant facilitators. The IAEA Technical Advisor (Article 11.6) shall be present if any allegation involves nuclear material.

If the consultation resolves the underlying issue, the intending Party shall withdraw the request and no non-renewal notice is filed. If the consultation does not resolve the issue, the intending Party may proceed to file the formal non-renewal notice under Appendix I §3, and the six-hour buffer under Article 2 then runs as written. Total time from initial cooling-off request to track termination is therefore not less than twelve (12) hours.

During the cooling-off window, all freeze obligations remain in full effect, the humanitarian corridor remains in full effect, and no Party may publicly announce an intention to terminate the Protocol. Public announcement during the cooling-off window is itself a Tier 2 incident under this Article.

The cooling-off consultation may be waived only in cases of active large-scale kinetic attack against the requesting Party's territory or forces (a Tier 3 trigger), in which case the matter proceeds directly to Tier 3 procedures rather than to non-renewal.

Article 13: Third-Party Spoiler Protocol

Where the JFMC determines, on the basis of conforming evidence under Article 11.2, that an incident was caused by a non-signatory actor — whether a regional proxy, an independent armed group, a state outside this Protocol, or an unidentified third party — the JFMC issues a 'Spoiler Determination' rather than a violation finding. A Spoiler Determination has the following consequences:

- No tier escalation against any signatory party is triggered.

- The affected signatory may take proportionate defensive action against the actual source of the incident, subject to the constraints of Article 9 and Appendix I §1 (imminent threat).
- The JFMC convenes an emergency consultation within 6 hours to coordinate a joint signatory response statement, preventing rival public attribution from spiralling.
- Where the spoiler is reasonably believed to be aligned with any signatory party, that party assumes a rebuttable burden of demonstrating non-coordination, addressed through the Annex C mechanism for Hezbollah-related incidents and through standard Article 12 procedures for other affiliations.

This article exists because every prior Middle East de-escalation framework has been destroyed by a single rocket from an actor no one at the table controls. The Spoiler Protocol prevents that single rocket from collapsing the entire architecture.

Article 14: Facilitator Fact-Finding Authority

Oman, Qatar, and the United States, acting jointly or individually within their domain primacy, may at any time propose a Fact-Finding Mission for a contested incident. Such a Mission consists of two to four neutral technical experts (typically drawn from the IAEA, UNIFIL, Lloyd's List Intelligence, or equivalent independent bodies) deployed to the incident site within 24 hours.

Critically, a Fact-Finding Mission does **not** require the consent of the party alleged to be at fault. It does require, at minimum, the consent of the territorial sovereign of the incident location — consent that is deemed granted by signature of this Protocol for territory under signatory party control. Refusal to permit a Fact-Finding Mission constitutes a Tier 2 incident under Article 12 independent of the underlying matter under investigation.

Findings of a Fact-Finding Mission are advisory only, but are deposited in full with the JFMC and distributed to all parties under Article 11.3.

Article 15: Standardised Non-Renewal Notification

A non-renewal notice under Article 2 (Track A) or Article 6/7 (Track B) is valid only if it satisfies the format requirements in Appendix I §3. In summary: a non-renewal notice must be a formal diplomatic note, signed by an official at the rank of foreign minister or head of government, transmitted exclusively through the JFMC Portal, specifying the article being terminated, the time of intended cessation (not earlier than six hours from receipt), and the reason invoked. Email, social media posts, verbal communications, press statements, or notices through diplomatic intermediaries outside the JFMC Portal do not constitute valid non-renewal and do not start the 6-hour clock.

Part VI: Entry Into Force and Duration

Article 16: Entry Into Force

This Protocol enters into force upon oral confirmation by authorised representatives of the participating Parties to their respective facilitators. Written signature is not required for initial entry into force. A joint written record of oral confirmation will be prepared by the JFMC within 12 hours and deposited with the UN Secretary-General.

16.1 – Six-Hour Synchronised Confirmation Window. All four Parties must confirm to their respective facilitators within a six-hour window opening at the moment of the first confirmation received. The first confirming Party shall wait, and the freeze does not begin running until the window closes. If at the close of the six-hour window fewer than all four Parties have confirmed, the Parties who did confirm may, at their joint discretion, proceed on a single-track basis (e.g., Track A only or Track B only). The Parties who failed to confirm within the window remain free to accede subsequently, but the freeze period of any track already activated runs from its own activation, not from late accession. This rule prevents any single Party from holding the entire architecture hostage by indefinite delay.

The oral confirmation mechanism is deliberate. It allows all capitals to implement the freeze immediately without the domestic political exposure of signing a formal document under current conditions. The written record follows implementation — it does not precede it.

Article 17: Duration, Linkage, and Relationship to Subsequent Agreements

This Protocol has no fixed expiry date. Each track continues, auto-renewing every 72 hours, until superseded by a more comprehensive agreement specific to that track. Upon entry into force of a Track A MOU covering operational matters in Articles 1 through 5, Track A is automatically suspended in favour of the MOU. The same applies to Track B upon any agreement emerging from the 29 May Washington talks. If those subsequent agreements collapse, this Protocol automatically reactivates.

This Protocol is the floor, not the ceiling. It holds the space open. Everything built above it — the MOU on the nuclear file, the Washington framework on Lebanon, the sanctions architecture, the disarmament process — rests on the assumption that this floor does not fall away.

17.1 – Linkage Bridge for the 29 May Washington Talks. If, prior to or during the 29 May 2026 Washington talks between Israel and the Lebanese Republic, technical, logistical, or scheduling difficulties prevent the talks from convening or concluding on schedule, either Party may request a single emergency 24-hour extension of Track B freeze obligations through the JFMC Portal. The extension is granted automatically upon request, requires no counter-signature, and may be invoked once per scheduling cycle. Repeated extensions require Tier 2 consultation under Article 12.1. This bridge ensures that the freeze cannot be defeated by an aircraft delay, a transit incident involving a delegation, or a procedural breakdown that has nothing to do with substantive disagreement.

Annex A: Domestic Narrative Guide

This annex offers factually accurate talking points for each Party's domestic audience. All sets of statements describe the same Protocol truthfully.

Track A – Strait of Hormuz

For the United States	For the Islamic Republic of Iran
<i>“We achieved a complete operational pause on Iranian aggression in the Strait.”</i> <i>“Hormuz is open. Oil is flowing. No tolls.”</i> <i>“Iran's IRGC fast-attack boats are at anchor. Their mine-layers are stood down.”</i> <i>“We retain full carrier strike group positioning. We gave up nothing permanent.”</i> <i>“The nuclear file is next — we have 30 to 60 days to get maximum leverage.”</i>	<i>“The illegal blockade of Iranian commercial ports is suspended.”</i> <i>“Iran's PGSA sovereignty over the Strait is explicitly preserved — not conceded.”</i> <i>“Our delegation in Doha is protected and negotiating from a position of strength.”</i> <i>“The HEU stockpile remains on Iranian soil. Nothing was transferred.”</i> <i>“This freeze was Iran's choice — we can end it with six hours notice at any time.”</i>

Track B – Israel-Lebanon Border

For the State of Israel	For the Lebanese Republic
<i>“We achieved a 72-hour cessation of Hezbollah fire on northern Israel.”</i> <i>“The Lebanese state has been compelled to deploy LAF against Hezbollah launch sites.”</i> <i>“Israel retains all current positions inside Lebanon. We did not withdraw.”</i> <i>“We did not negotiate with Hezbollah, and we never will.”</i> <i>“The Washington talks of 29 May proceed from a position of strength.”</i>	<i>“The Lebanese state is exercising sovereign authority over its territory.”</i> <i>“Israeli airstrikes on Lebanese soil are paused. Civilian casualties stop.”</i> <i>“We are pursuing a peaceful resolution through direct talks, as we promised.”</i> <i>“The LAF, not any non-state actor, is the sole legitimate armed force in Lebanon.”</i> <i>“This Protocol respects Lebanese sovereignty and contains no foreign-imposed terms.”</i>

Annex B: Why This Protocol Is Achievable Today

Four factors make a minimal dual-track freeze achievable on 26 May 2026:

- 1. All delegations are already in motion.** The Iranian delegation is in Doha. U.S. counterparts are engaged. The Israeli and Lebanese delegations are due in Washington on 29 May. The facilitators are active on both tracks. The infrastructure for communication exists. This Protocol asks the parties to do one thing before anything else: confirm a freeze to the facilitators already sitting across from them.
- 2. Every leader can claim the freeze as a victory.** Trump has already said a deal is 'largely negotiated.' A freeze allows him to claim it has begun — on both fronts. Tehran has already said the blockade is illegal and the PGSA is sovereign; a freeze that suspends the blockade and preserves the PGSA's legal status allows Tehran to claim it has prevailed. Netanyahu can claim he forced Hezbollah fire to stop and the Lebanese state to deploy against Hezbollah. The Lebanese government can claim it has exercised state sovereignty and stopped Israeli airstrikes on Lebanese soil.
- 3. The cost of continued escalation is symmetric and high.** Today's strikes near Bandar Abbas rattled the Gulf and pushed oil prices higher. The strike on Mashghara killed twelve people including children. Iran's army has threatened a 'far more severe' response. Netanyahu is being urged by ultra-right ministers to resume strikes on Beirut. No party benefits from the next 72 hours of operational contact on either front.
- 4. The Protocol is explicitly not a surrender document.** Iran does not transfer the HEU. The U.S. does not lift sanctions permanently. The PGSA is not dissolved. Israel does not withdraw. Lebanon does not formally disarm Hezbollah. Hezbollah is not asked to sign anything. Nothing here cannot be walked back tomorrow. The only irreversible element is the humanitarian corridor — and every party can defend that to any domestic audience.

A NOTE ON TODAY'S STRIKES: The 26 May CENTCOM strikes near Bandar Abbas and the 26 May Israeli strikes near Mashghara and along the Litani are the triggering context — the reason urgency is real — not a fundamental breach of good faith. The question is not who struck last. The question is whether all four parties stop now.

Appendix I: Technical Definitions

This Appendix is binding on all Parties with equal legal force as the main articles of the Protocol. References to '§' indicate sections of this Appendix.

§1 – Imminent Physical Threat (referenced in Articles 1, 6, 9, 13)

An 'imminent physical threat' authorising self-defence under this Protocol exists only where all three of the following conditions are simultaneously satisfied:

- **(a) Kinetic indicator present:** active weapons lock, missile or rocket launch detection, drone in attack profile within 30 km of the responding party's forces, mine-laying operation in progress, or visually confirmed live munitions on a platform within engagement range.
- **(b) Temporal window:** the threat is assessed as resulting in physical harm to personnel, vessels, aircraft, or fixed infrastructure within fifteen (15) minutes of launch detection or visual acquisition of targeting absent intervention. Threats with a longer horizon are not 'imminent' for purposes of this Protocol and must be reported through Article 11 channels rather than addressed kinetically. Speculative intelligence assessments, signals analysis, or political risk evaluations do not satisfy this condition regardless of their probability estimate.
- **(c) Last resort:** no defensive measure short of kinetic response — manoeuvre, electronic countermeasures, JFMC emergency notification, warning shot — is reasonably available within the temporal window.

Surveillance overflights, electronic posture changes, troop movements, public threats, social media statements, rhetorical escalation, and unverified intelligence reports do **not** constitute imminent threats under this Appendix.

§2 – The JFMC Portal (referenced in Article 11.1)

The JFMC Portal is a dedicated end-to-end encrypted web application hosted on Omani sovereign infrastructure in Muscat, with redundant failover in Doha. Access credentials are issued to a maximum of twelve authorised representatives per signatory party (four political-level, four military-level, four technical-level). The Portal supports structured incident submission, file attachments up to 500 MB per report (for sensor logs and imagery), and immutable server-side timestamping using a multi-source NTP reference. Redundant backup channels are: (i) encrypted satellite phone link to the JFMC duty officer; (ii) Omani diplomatic pouch for materials exceeding electronic transmission capacity. Reports submitted through any other channel are non-conforming.

§3 – Non-Renewal Notice Format (referenced in Article 15)

A valid non-renewal notice must include all of the following elements, in the order specified, transmitted exclusively through the JFMC Portal:

- Header identifying the document as a 'Notice of Non-Renewal' under SFP-2026-v1.4.
- Identification of the issuing Party and the official signatory (foreign minister, head of government, or designated equivalent).
- Identification of the specific Track (A or B) being terminated. A single notice cannot terminate both tracks.
- Date and time of intended cessation, expressed in UTC, not earlier than 6 hours and not later than 72 hours from receipt.
- Statement of grounds invoked.
- Cryptographic signature using the issuing Party's Portal credentials.

The 6-hour countdown clock begins at the moment of Portal-confirmed delivery, not at the moment of any public statement. Public announcements made prior to or in lieu of Portal submission have no legal effect on this Protocol.

§4 – Humanitarian Cargo (referenced in Article 4)

Cargo qualifies for the humanitarian corridor only if it falls within the categories below, identified by Harmonized System (HS) tariff codes where applicable, and is certified by the WHO, ICRC, IFRC, OCHA, UNHCR, or WFP:

Category	HS Code Range	Examples
Pharmaceuticals	HS 3001–3006	Antibiotics, insulin, vaccines, dialysis fluids, oncology drugs
Medical devices	HS 9018–9022	Surgical instruments, diagnostic equipment, oxygen concentrators
Staple foods	HS 1001–1008, 1101–1107, 0401–0410	Wheat, rice, flour, infant formula, milk powder, edible oils
Drinking water & water treatment	HS 2201; 8421.21	Bottled potable water, filtration units, purification tablets
Civilian fuel for heating, cooking, medical facilities	HS 2710.19 (kerosene); HS 2711 (LPG); diesel for hospital generators only	Kerosene for civilian heating, LPG cylinders for domestic cooking
Emergency shelter materials	HS 6306; HS 9406	Tents, tarpaulins, prefabricated shelters
Sanitation and hygiene	HS 3401; HS 4818; HS 6307.10	Soap, sanitary products, cleaning supplies

Dual-use items, items not on this list, and items with credible military application (including but not limited to night-vision equipment, hardened communications gear, and industrial-grade chemical precursors) are excluded from the humanitarian corridor regardless of stated end-use. Disputes over classification are resolved by the WHO or ICRC representative attached to the JFMC, whose determination is binding for the duration of the freeze period.

§5 – Known Hezbollah Launch Points (referenced in Article 7)

For purposes of LAF deployment under Article 7, 'known Hezbollah launch points' means the set of geographic locations satisfying any one of the following criteria:

- **(a)** Locations documented in the UNIFIL Geographic Launch Site Registry as having been used for the launch of rockets, missiles, mortars, or armed drones directed at Israeli territory between 8 April 2026 and the entry-into-force date of this Protocol.
- **(b)** Locations identified by UNIFIL during the freeze period, on the basis of observed launch activity or pre-launch indicators, and communicated to the LAF Chief of Staff and the JFMC within four hours of observation.
- **(c)** Locations identified by Israeli intelligence and shared with the LAF through the JFMC, accompanied by conforming evidence under Article 11.2, where the evidence is independently corroborated by either UNIFIL or a Facilitator Fact-Finding Mission.

The LAF deployment obligation under Article 7 attaches to (a) immediately upon entry into force, and to (b) and (c) within six hours of communication. The LAF is not required to disarm; it is required to physically interpose. A location ceases to be 'known' for purposes of this section after 72 hours of no observed activity.

§6 – Significant Israeli Casualties (referenced in Article 9)

'Significant Israeli casualties' triggering Track B collapse under Article 9(a) means either:

- **(a)** Ten (10) or more confirmed deaths, including IDF personnel, civilians, or dual-citizens lawfully present in Israel, attributable to a single Hezbollah action or a coordinated series of Hezbollah actions occurring within a 24-hour window; OR
- **(b)** Twenty (20) or more confirmed serious injuries requiring hospitalisation for more than 48 hours, with the same attribution and time-window requirements as (a); OR
- **(c)** Any successful strike on Israeli strategic infrastructure (defined as international airports, principal power generation facilities, principal desalination plants, Knesset, Prime Minister's Office, or Ministry of Defence headquarters), regardless of casualty count.

Attribution is determined by the JFMC on the basis of conforming evidence, and may be tested by a Facilitator Fact-Finding Mission under Article 14. Attribution disputes do not toll the 24-hour assessment window but do affect the final classification.

§7 – Reading Convention

Where any provision of the main Protocol and this Appendix are in tension, the Appendix governs as the more specific text. Where the Appendix is silent, the main Protocol applies in its ordinary meaning, interpreted in light of the Protocol's object and purpose: the prevention of further armed contact on both fronts during the negotiation period.

Annex C: Iran – Hezbollah Restraint Annex (Classified)

Annex C is a binding classified instrument of equal legal force as the public articles of this Protocol. It records the commitment by the Islamic Republic of Iran, referenced in Article 8, that operations conducted by Hezbollah during the freeze period will receive no logistical support, materiel transfer, intelligence support, political defence, or financial backing from any organ of the Iranian state, the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, the Quds Force, or any entity acting on their behalf.

The full text of Annex C is deposited under seal with the Omani Ministry of Foreign Affairs and is accessible only to the JFMC Compliance Monitors of Oman and the United States, the Iranian Foreign Minister, and the U.S. Secretary of State. Its existence is publicly acknowledged in this Protocol; its content is not published during the freeze period.

Breach of Annex C is a Track A compliance issue under Article 12 and is independently actionable. Discovery of breach through Facilitator Fact-Finding (Article 14) triggers Tier 2 procedures with no requirement of Tier 1 escalation.

Instruments of Acceptance

This Protocol may be accepted orally (confirmation to facilitators), in writing (signature below), or by electronic communication to the JFMC Portal. All three methods produce identical legal effect. No domestic legislative approval is required for the initial 72-hour period.

Track A – Southern Front

For the United States of America

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

For the Islamic Republic of Iran

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

Track B – Northern Front

For the State of Israel

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

For the Lebanese Republic

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

Witness — Oman

Track A — primary

Witness — Qatar

Track A — delegation host

Witness — United States

Track B — primary